פרשת יתרו, which connects יתרו's arrival to join כלל ישראל with the עשרת הדיברות, has intrigued מפרשים throughout history, prompting them to explore the relationship between these events. In my younger days, I used a very בעלבתישע explanation: יתרו gave משה רבינו a practical עצה, so הקדוש ברוך הוא rewarded him by placing the עשרת הדיברות in פרשת יתרו.

On a deeper level, יתרו's experiences serve as an introduction to the עשרת הדיברות, particularly לא תחמד. As the בית הלוי points out, לא תחמד is an exceptionally challenging מצוה; how is it possible for us to control our innermost thoughts and not want something which we should not have?

The בית הלוי offers two תירוצים. The first is from the אבן עזרא, that by cultivating יראת שמים and recognizing that some things are simply beyond our reach, we can train ourselves not to desire them. He uses a משל of a farmhand watching a princess's carriage pass by; the farmhand feels no desire for her because she is beyond his ken. Similarly, we should consider certain desires as unattainable, thereby removing them from our sphere of interest.

The second תירוץ, a classic one, illustrates how momentary יראה can dissolve even the strongest תאוות. Imagine someone driven by a strong תַּאֲוָה, he really wants to do something, whatever it may be, whether it's money or business or wasting time or going to the movies or whatever תַּאֲוָה he has, and he's rushing to fulfill it on a stormy winter day [as we have here in New York. I'm happy for all of our relatives who are in warmer climates and enjoying the weather, but here it is cold and it's getting colder.] As he hurries, he slips on an icy patch, and in that instant of falling, all his desires vanish. The בית הלוי teaches that even a small amount of יראת שמים, akin to the fear of falling, can greatly diminish one's יצר הרע. By focusing on יראת שמים, contemplating the גדלות הבורא and keeping in mind שִׁוִּיתִי ה׳ לְנֶגְדִּי תָּמִיד, we can make the מצוה of לא תחמד more attainable; if not easy, then certainly easier.

A pathway to achieve an inkling into Hashem's infinite greatness is to recognize His ability to know our thoughts. יתרו's story exemplifies this belief. יתרו said, "I witnessed פרעה and his advisors plotting in secret. Hashem repaid them מידה כנגד מידה with the exact punishments corresponding to their plots against כלל ישראל. This proved to me that הקדוש ברוך הוא knows our innermost thoughts."

יתרו's story is a beautiful introduction to the עשרת הדיברות. The אמונה he attained by witnessing Hashem's כח is a lesson for us in יראת שמים, the purpose of the עשרת הדיברות.

https://youtu.be/ulS4j_VfJvk